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California Advances Comprehensive Strategy to PreventHomelessness Before It Starts, Sending Bill to Governor's Desk

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Today, the California State Legislature passed Assembly Bill (AB) 1924, statewide legislation poised to address a critical part of California's homelessness epidemic by preventing displacement before it occurs. Authored by Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel

(D-Encino) and Sharon Quirk-Silva (D-Fullerton), the bill directs the state to build California's first comprehensive homelessness prevention strategy, complete with measurable goals, accountability benchmarks, and model best practices that cities and counties can use as guidance. AB 1924 passed the State Senate by a 40-0 vote, and the State Assembly by a vote of 77-1.

The numbers behind this bill make the case. Nearly 190,000 Californians are experiencing

homelessness, and for every person who exits it, nearly three more fall into homelessness for the first time — a ratio that climbs to 4-to-1 in regions like Los Angeles County. California has invested significant dollars into shelters and housing to catch people after they fall. AB 1924 directs the state to spend that money more efficiently, by keeping people from falling in the first place.

"The best way to reduce homelessness is to keep more Californians housed," said

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino). "We know that prevention is the most humane, compassionate, and cost-effective approach to this crisis and its long past time California adopted a statewide strategy. This legislation will implement a proven strategy and require real accountability so we can finally start to move the needle on this terrible crisis."

"California cannot solve homelessness by waiting until someone has already lost their home. We must do more to keep people housed in the first place, especially when timely support can prevent a family from losing everything," said Assemblymember Sharon Quirk-Silva (D-Fullerton). "AB 1924 gives California a stronger framework to identify what works, coordinate prevention efforts, and measure whether we are reaching the people who need help before they enter homelessness. Thank you, Assemblymember Gabriel, for ensuring California is smarter with our resources and giving families a better chance to remain safely and securely housed."

Proof of Concept Already Exists Prevention is not a theory. Homelessness prevention programs are already established in Santa Clara County, Sonoma County, and elsewhere throughout the state. Innovative programs like homelessness prevention units, which predict who is most likely to become homeless and intervene before help is sought, demonstrate what the future of prevention could look like. What has been missing is a statewide framework to connect these efforts, measure what works, and scale it statewide.

AB 1924 gives the state a way to connect the dots. The bill requires the California Interagency Council on Homelessness to develop a statewide homelessness prevention strategy, including goals and accountability measures. It directs relevant state agencies to build their own homelessness prevention action plans, and requires the state to identify and disseminate evidence-based model practices that local governments and service providers can adopt.

What Experts and Community Leaders Are Saying "Preventing homelessness is much more humane and vastly less expensive than waiting to react to it. Yet for all California's investments on homelessness, the state has done little to prevent it in the first place. This bill makes prevention a strategic priority, moving California toward the cutting

edge of nationwide efforts to solve our homelessness crisis." — Mike Feuer, Senior Policy Advisor at Inner City Law Center

"We've seen prevention programs in the Bay Area and Los Angeles start turning the tide on people becoming homeless. This bill would direct California to develop a statewide strategy to implement these critical programs for the first time. Independent researchers have proven how effective homelessness prevention can be at keeping people housed even months after they received assistance, and we hope the state will build off this experience to bring these programs statewide." — Brett Andrews, Interim CEO of All Home

"The best way to end homelessness is to stop it before it starts. Prevention is not only the most compassionate approach, it is also cost-effective, proven to work, and gives families a chance to stay safely housed before a crisis becomes a catastrophe. California has an opportunity right now to make prevention a priority through AB 1924 and take a meaningful first step toward helping thousands of families stay in their homes." — Jennifer Loving, CEO of Destination: Home

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